PADHAKU
Footprints without Feet · Class 10 English



CHAPTER 2

The Thief's Story

NCERT Exercise Solutions

The Thief's Story · Read and Find Out (1) 3 Q

The Thief's Story · Read and Find Out (2) 3 Q

The Thief's Story · Think about It 2 Q

The Thief's Story · Talk about It 4 Q

✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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⭐ The Thief's Story · Read and Find Out (1)

1 **Who does ‘I’ refer to in this story?**

✔ ANSWER

‘I’ refers to the narrator, a 15-year-old thief who calls himself **Hari Singh**. He takes a new name every month to stay ahead of the police and his former employers.

2 **What is he “a fairly successful hand” at?**

✔ ANSWER

He is a fairly successful hand at **stealing** (being a thief). Though only 15, he was an “experienced and fairly successful” thief.

3 **What does he get from Anil in return for his work?**

✔ ANSWER

Anil cannot pay him money. In return for cooking and other work, he gets **food**, a place to **sleep on the balcony**, and lessons in **cooking, writing his name, writing sentences and adding numbers**.

⭐ The Thief's Story · Read and Find Out (2)

1 **How does the thief think Anil will react to the theft?**

✔ ANSWER

The thief thinks Anil's face will show only **a touch of sadness** — not for the loss of money, but for the **loss of trust**.

2 **What does he say about the different reactions of people when they are robbed?**

✔ ANSWER

He says that when people are robbed:

- the **greedy** man shows **fear**;
- the **rich** man shows **anger**;
- the **poor** man shows **acceptance**.

3 **Does Anil realise that he has been robbed?**

✔ ANSWER

Yes. The next morning Anil gives Hari a fifty-rupee note that is **still wet from the night's rain**. So Anil knows about the theft and its return, but "neither his lips nor his eyes showed anything".

🤔 The Thief's Story · Think about It

1 **What are Hari Singh's reactions to the prospect of receiving an education? Do they change over time? (Hint: Compare, for example, the thought: "I knew that once I could write like an educated man there would be no limit to what I could achieve" with these later thoughts: "Whole sentences, I knew, could one day bring me more than a few hundred rupees. It was a simple matter to steal — and sometimes just as simple to be caught. But to be a really big man, a clever and respected man, was something else.") What makes him return to Anil?**

✔ ANSWER

At first: Hari is grateful when Anil teaches him to write his name. He thinks that once he can write like an educated man, "there would be no limit" to what he could achieve. Education is only a tool to become a smarter, more successful person, perhaps even a better thief.

Later: After the theft, sitting wet under the clock tower, he realises that stealing is easy but one can just as easily be caught. Education can bring him much more than a few hundred rupees — it can make him "a really big man, a clever and respected man". So his view changes: he now sees education as the way to an honest, respected life.

Why he returns: He misses the chance of learning to read and write. He tells himself he should go back to Anil "if only to learn to read and write". Anil's trust and kindness also weigh on him (he hesitates to board the train and has nowhere else to go), so he returns the money.

2 **Why does not Anil hand the thief over to the police? Do you think most people would have done so? In what ways is Anil different from such employers?**

✔ ANSWER

Anil does not hand Hari over to the police because Hari has **returned the money** on his own. Anil is kind and understanding; he sees that the boy has a good side and wants to **reform him**, not punish him. So he pays Hari regularly and says, "Today we'll start writing sentences."

Most people would have handed a thief over to the police, or at least thrown him out.

How Anil is different:

- He is trusting: he gives Hari a key and lets him come and go.
- He is generous: he does not mind Hari making a little money on the shopping.
- He is forgiving and patient: he hides his knowledge of the theft and does not insult Hari.

- He cares about the boy's future and teaches him to cook, read, write and add.

⭐ The Thief's Story · Talk about It

1 Do you think people like Anil and Hari Singh are found only in fiction, or are there such people in real life?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Such people exist in real life too.

- Many poor, homeless children like Hari turn to petty theft to survive, but can change when someone shows them trust and gives them education.
- There are also kind, simple people like Anil — teachers, social workers, neighbours — who help such children and give them a second chance.

The story feels real because these characters are true to life.

2 Do you think it a significant detail in the story that Anil is a struggling writer? Does this explain his behaviour in any way?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Yes, it is significant.

- As a writer, Anil values **education** and knows its power, so he wants to teach Hari.

- He himself earns “by fits and starts” and knows hardship, so he understands a poor boy’s situation.
- Writers are often sensitive and observant of people; this explains his kindness, trust, and his quiet way of handling the theft instead of calling the police.
- Being careless about money, he does not mind small losses.

3 **Have you met anyone like Hari Singh? Can you think and imagine the circumstances that can turn a fifteen-year-old boy into a thief?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

(Personal answer — sample points)

Circumstances that can turn a boy into a thief:

- **Poverty** and hunger; no money for food or shelter.
- Being an **orphan** or running away from home; no family care.
- **No education** and no chance of a job.
- Bad company or being used by adult criminals.
- Lack of love, guidance and trust from anyone.

Like Hari, such a boy can change if someone gives him care, trust and education.

4 **Where is the story set? (You can get clues from the names of the persons and places mentioned in it.) Which language or languages are spoken in these places? Do you think the characters in the story spoke to each other in English?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

The story is set in a town of **North India**, most likely in **Uttar Pradesh** — the clues are the **Jumna Sweet Shop** (Yamuna river), the **Lucknow Express**, names like **Anil** and **Hari Singh**, the bazaar, the maidan and the clock tower.

Hindi (and Urdu) is spoken in these places.

The characters most probably spoke to each other in **Hindi**, not English, because Hari is an uneducated street boy who could not even write his name. The author has written their conversation in English for his readers.

🎉 **Chapter 2 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**